

India's Security Doctrine: Shift Towards Deterrence by Punishment



For Prelims: PRAHAAR , Operation Sindoor , Indus Waters Treaty (1960) , Attari-Wagah Integrated Check Post , Positive Indigenization Lists , iDEX (Innovations for Defence Excellence)

For Mains: Perimeter Fallacy and emerging borderless security threats, India's shift from deterrence by denial to deterrence by punishment, Multi-domain warfare and national security

Source: IE

Why in News?

The Defence Minister of India outlined a decisive shift in India's national security doctrine at **DefCon 2026** . He cautioned policymakers against the "**perimeter fallacy**" and announced that India's strategic approach has formally evolved from "strategic containment" and "**deterrence by denial**" toward a proactive posture of "**deterrence by punishment**" .

Summary

- India is shifting from "strategic containment" and "deterrence by denial" toward a proactive posture of "deterrence by punishment", addressing cyberattacks, drones, gray-zone warfare, energy vulnerabilities and critical technology dependencies.
- Building resilience requires defence indigenisation, integrated military commands, intelligence-led counter-terrorism, critical infrastructure protection and whole-of-government coordination.

What is the 'Perimeter Fallacy'?

- **Definition:** The term "perimeter fallacy" refers to the **misconception or assumption** that national security can be understood and managed solely by safeguarding a country's physical, geographical boundaries.
- **Fluidity of Modern Threats:** While territorial borders remain geographically fixed, the **nature of**

modern conflict has evolved, making the boundaries of threats highly fluid. Security threats are increasingly borderless and extend far beyond conventional battlefields.

- **New Fronts of Warfare:** Relying only on **border fortifications and troop deployments is inadequate to combat modern-day vulnerabilities** such as drone and unmanned system incursions, cyberattacks, disinformation campaigns, and lone-wolf attacks.
- **Economic & Energy Security Integration:** Security is no longer limited to the military domain. Hostile actors can bypass physical borders to disrupt critical supply chains and damage the economy.
 - For instance, India's heavy reliance on imported crude oil makes global chokepoints, such as the **Strait of Hormuz**, a critical vulnerability that directly impacts national security.

What is India's Shift Towards Deterrence by Punishment?

- **Deterrence:** It refers to the strategy of discouraging adversaries from undertaking **hostile actions by influencing their assessment** of risks and costs. It works by creating uncertainty about the success of an attack and increasing the expected consequences of aggression.
- **Deterrence by Denial:** Historically, **India relied heavily on this strategy, operating on the logic that an attack** will fail because defensive measures (like fortifying borders or hardening domestic targets) will successfully thwart it.
- **Deterrence by Punishment:** In contrast, the new approach of "deterrence by punishment" focuses on shifting from merely preventing attacks to imposing **credible and unacceptable costs** on adversaries after hostile actions.
 - Its effectiveness depends on **credible retaliatory capabilities, clear signalling, and political-military preparedness** to respond decisively when red lines are crossed.

Institutionalizing the Shift Towards Deterrence by Punishment

- **Kinetic Retaliation:** This paradigm shift has been practically demonstrated through successive, high-impact military actions. The **2016 Surgical Strikes**, the **2019 Balakot air strikes**, and **Operation Sindoor (2025)** clearly establish India's resolve to cross physical borders to dismantle terror infrastructure directly at its source.
- **The PRAHAAR Strategy:** To institutionalize this proactive stance, India formulated PRAHAAR, its first comprehensive National Counter-Terrorism Policy and Strategy. It explicitly mandates a "zero-tolerance" approach, replacing ad-hoc reactive measures with an intelligence-driven, "whole-of-government" framework aimed at neutralizing asymmetric threats before they materialize.
- **Diplomatic and Economic Coercion:** Deterrence by punishment extends beyond the battlefield into aggressive statecraft. India has successfully leveraged diplomatic measures in the **Financial Action Task Force (FATF)** and other multilateral institutions, ensuring that Pakistan remains isolated on the global stage.
 - Actions such as **keeping the Indus Waters Treaty (1960) in abeyance, suspending bilateral trade, and closing the Attari-Wagah Integrated Check Post**, alongside **multilateral diplomacy and credible military power**, reflect India's broader multi-domain security approach.



What are the Challenges to India's Security Architecture?

- **The "Perimeter Fallacy" and Borderless Threats:** Focusing disproportionately on physical frontiers leaves the nation vulnerable to **non-kinetic, borderless vectors** such as **state-sponsored cyber warfare**, autonomous drone swarms, and AI-driven disinformation campaigns targeting domestic social cohesion.
 - The **November 2025 Red Fort car bombing** highlighted how terrorists can combine **physical operations with encrypted digital communication**. It showed that **digital networks can enable asymmetric threats** beyond conventional border security.
- **Critical Energy and Maritime Chokepoints:** India relies on imports for over 85% of its crude oil. Chokepoints such as the **Strait of Hormuz** and shipping corridors in the **Red Sea/Gulf of Aden** (vulnerable to non-state actors like Houthis) expose the economy to severe freight spikes, supply disruptions, and insurance surcharges.
- **Supply Chain Dependencies in Critical Technologies:** Reliance on external suppliers for **semiconductors**, advanced electronics, **Active Pharmaceutical Ingredients (APIs)**, and **rare earth elements** leaves India's military-industrial complex vulnerable to geopolitical coercion and global supply shocks.
- **Two-Front Collusive Gray-Zone Warfare:** The operational convergence between China and Pakistan manifests not only in **conventional threats** but in **"gray-zone" tactics—actions below the threshold of open war**.
 - This includes border infrastructure expansion, cyber espionage, proxy insurgencies, and intelligence

sharing, such as China providing intelligence support to Pakistan during India's Operation Sindoor.

- **Grassroots Technological Asymmetry:** While apex agencies like the **National Critical Information Infrastructure Protection Centre (NCIIPC)** and **Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C)** possess advanced capabilities, state-level police forces face technical deficits in digital evidence extraction, drone interception, and counter-terror investigation under the **Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam (BSA), 2023** .

What Measures are Needed to Build a Resilient Security Architecture?

- **Operationalizing Integrated Theatre Commands (ITCs):** Move rapidly toward creating **integrated theater commands** (Western, Eastern, and Maritime) to ensure unified resource allocation, joint planning, and swift tri-service kinetic retaliatory execution under the **Chief of Defence Staff (CDS)**.
- **Deepening Defense Indigenization and R&D:** Expand the **Positive Indigenization Lists** (currently covering 5,500+ items) to reduce import dependencies in frontline platforms.
 - Scale up the **iDEX (Innovations for Defence Excellence)** initiative and ensure that the **25% defense R&D budget earmarked for private industry and academia** translates into sovereign intellectual property for electronic warfare, quantum encryption, and counter-drone systems.
- **Critical Infrastructure Hardening:** Mandate automated, real-time cyber telemetry sharing between public utilities, the banking sector, telecom infrastructure, and **CERT-In** to prevent systemic collapses triggered by cross-border cyber intrusions.
- **Securing Strategic Economic Buffers:** Expand the capacity of **Strategic Petroleum Reserves (SPRs)** beyond the current 9.5-day commercial buffer to build resilience against maritime blockades.
 - Diversify maritime trade through alternate logistics frameworks such as the **India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC)** .
- **Whole-of-Government Law Enforcement Convergence:** Institutionalize mandatory, real-time integration between national intelligence grids (**NATGRID** , **Samanvaya platform**) and local police stations to disrupt proxy terror networks, illicit terror finance, and cyber syndicates before they manifest into national crises.
- **Strengthening Multi-Domain Security** : India needs coordinated preparedness across land, maritime, cyber, space, economic and information domains to address evolving threats.

Conclusion

India's doctrinal shift from passive border containment to proactive deterrence by punishment marks a pragmatic adaptation to modern, multi-domain warfare. By integrating kinetic readiness with economic resilience, critical energy security, and institutional frameworks like PRAHAAR, the nation establishes a credible threshold against asymmetric aggression.

Drishti Mains Question:

India's shift from deterrence by denial to deterrence by punishment represents a change in its strategic posture. Discuss.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the “Perimeter Fallacy”?

The **Perimeter Fallacy** is the assumption that national security can be ensured mainly by protecting physical borders, overlooking **cyber, economic, technological, informational and other borderless threats** .

2. What is deterrence by punishment?

Deterrence by punishment seeks to discourage hostile action by imposing **retaliatory costs that outweigh the potential gains** of an attack, unlike deterrence by denial, which focuses on preventing the attack from succeeding.

3. What is PRAHAAR?

PRAHAAR is described as India’s comprehensive **National Counter-Terrorism Policy and Strategy** , emphasising **prevention, intelligence-led action, coordinated response and whole-of-government counter-terrorism efforts** .

4. Why are Integrated Theatre Commands important?

Integrated Theatre Commands (ITCs) aim to enhance **tri-service coordination, joint planning, resource optimisation and operational effectiveness** across different theatres.

5. How can India strengthen resilience against emerging security threats?

India needs greater **defence indigenisation, critical-infrastructure protection, cyber resilience, strategic energy buffers, intelligence coordination and grassroots technological capacity** to address multi-domain threats.

[Watch Video on YouTube: [▶ https://www.youtube.com/embed/objVfMWASNI](https://www.youtube.com/embed/objVfMWASNI)]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Mains

Q. What are India’s internal security challenges? Give out the role of Central Intelligence and Investigative Agencies tasked to counter such threats. **(2023)**

Q. Analyse the multidimensional challenges posed by external state and non-state actors, to the internal security of India. Also discuss measures required to be taken to combat the threats. **(2021)**

Q. The banning of ‘Jamaat-e – islaami’ in Jammu and Kashmir brought into focus the role of over-ground workers (OGWs) in assisting terrorist organizations. Examine the role played by OGWs in assisting terrorist organizations in insurgency affected areas. Discuss measures to neutralize the influence of OGWs. **(2019)**